



Tough start: Egypt will play Brazil in a friendly in Cleveland on June 6, before opening its World Cup campaign against Belgium in Seattle nine days later. REUTERS

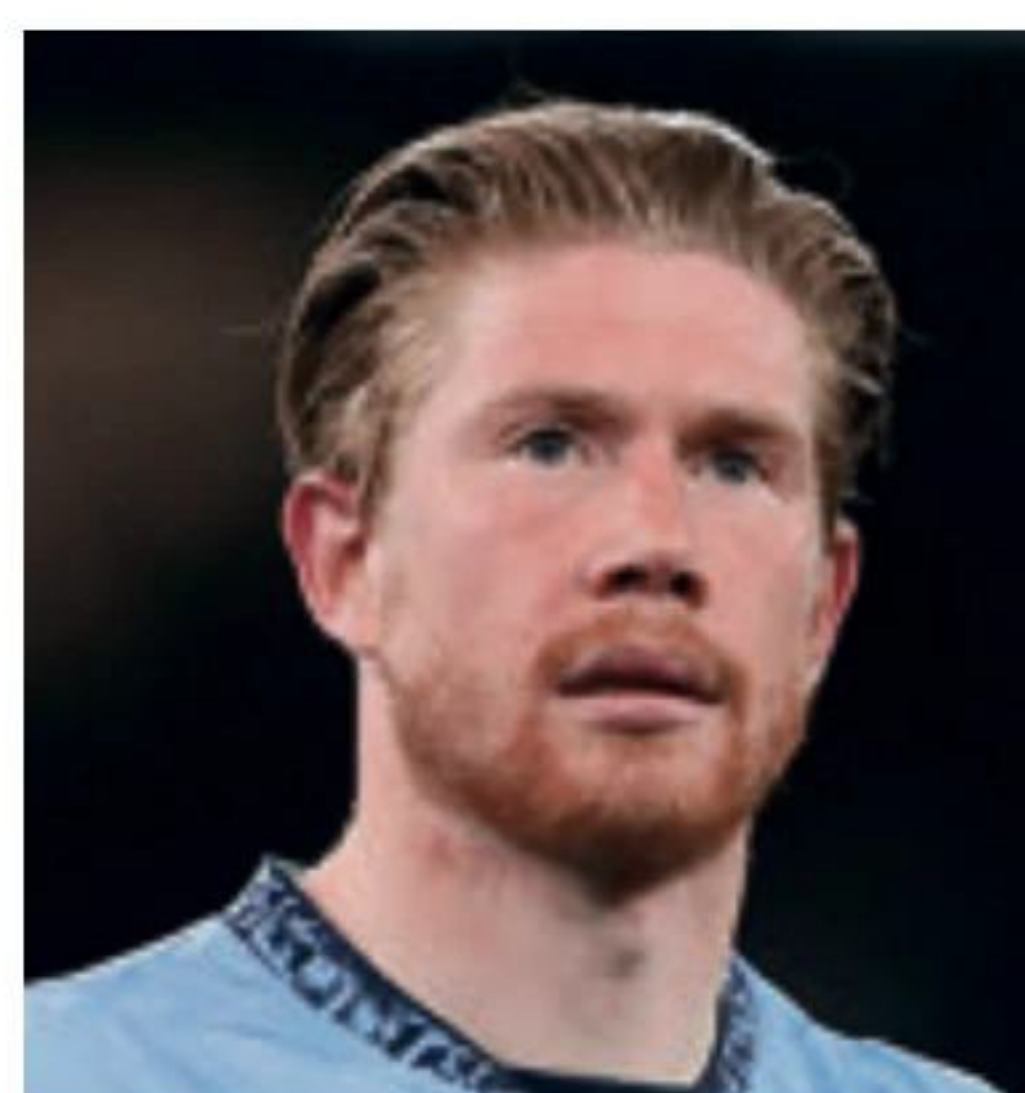
taking place on the west coast of the United States and Canada. If Belgium tops Group G, it will face one of the best third-placed teams from Groups A, E, H, I or J. If it finishes second, it will meet the runner-up from Group D, a route that could quickly become complicated.

That makes the Egypt match more important than it first appears. Belgium can still win the group, but an opening stumble could push it into a more difficult race.

Egypt carries its own burden. Salah is not just the face of the team; he remains the country's best route to control and goals. Alongside him, Marmoush provides pace, movement and a second elite attacking outlet. Under Hossam Hassan, Egypt possesses enough defensive resilience and attacking experience to believe it can finally improve its modest World Cup record. It has never won a match at the tournament, but this group offers a realistic opportunity to change that. If it can avoid defeat against Belgium, matches against New Zealand and Iran could become a clear path to the knockouts.

Iran is the awkward team in the group, both on and off the pitch. Ranked above Egypt and comfortably ahead of New Zealand, Amir Ghalenoei's side has enough experience to reach the round of 32. Mehdi Taremi remains the central attacking figure, Alireza Beiranvand

ON THE RADAR



Kevin De Bruyne (Belgium)

Belgium still looks a different side when De Bruyne has time on the ball. His passing range, set-piece delivery and ability to dictate tempo remain central to its attacking structure. If Belgium is to manage games and avoid chaos, it will be him who has to set the rhythm.



Mohamed Salah (Egypt)

Salah once again carries Egypt's hopes, but this time with stronger attacking support around him. His movement from the right, finishing with his left foot and ability to create chances under pressure make him the player most likely to decide Egypt's biggest matches.